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DEPARTMENT OF STATE

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Memorandum of Conversation

DATE:
January 4, 1950

SUBJECT:
Formosa Problem.

PARTICIPANTS:
Cong. John Kee, Chairman, House Foreign Affairs Committee.
The Secretary
Mr. McFall - H

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The Secretary spent about fifteen minutes discussing the Formosa problem in Judge Kee's apartment. The Secretary traced briefly the history of the problem, indicating that save for a hiatus of some forty years, when it was occupied by the Japanese, Formosa had always belonged to China. He pointed out that at the Cairo Conference the Big Four agreed to give Formosa to China and that this attitude was reaffirmed at Potsdam. He then stressed that it was absolutely essential in our international dealings that our word be respected and that we not lay ourselves open for damaging Russian charges that would surely result if we were to make any overt military action to protect Formosa.

He then developed the present situation in Formosa calling attention to the large number of troops, airforce and Navy, that are on the Island; that they are well equipped with arms, armaments and implements of war and that as far as their military potentialities are concerned, there is no possible way that the Communists on the mainland could achieve a military conquest by invasion as they do not have landing barges and necessary military equipment to bring about a successful incursion. The Secretary pointed out the fact that if Formosa did fall to the Communists by way of an internal falling apart, that we would still have the sea and air controls over the Island. He said that there seems to be some magic that flows from the use of the term "island" which seems to immediately give everyone the jitters, whereas, if Formosa had happened to be a peninsula we would probably have heard nothing more about it.

A few other brief observations were made by the Secretary to which Judge Kee gave an enthusiastic Amen. The Judge stated that he was in complete and entire sympathy with the Secretary's expressed attitude and that he could count on him fully for all support that he might lend toward upholding the Administration view on this policy in both the Foreign Affairs Committee and in the House.

JKMcFall:cd